

The Zohar Expedition

Discovering (parts) of the Far East in 33 Days

September 15, 2013 – October 17, 2013

Introduction:

We have travelled the world over but never to the Far East. We were never drawn to it for one reason or another and some point conceded that we may never travel to this part of the world. 2013 has been a big year for us as we both turned 70 and celebrated our 50th wedding anniversary with the entire family in style in Hawaii this summer (see the documentary Hawaii50) This all changed when mom received a flyer from the Royal Ontario Museum (ROM) announcing a tour to the Himalayans (Tibet, Nepal and Bhutan). It was truly intriguing and more so when we discovered that it was fully booked. We located GeoEx of California who offered an identical itinerary to that of the ROM and signed up to their Himalayan Kingdom tour. As this16 day tour originates from Beijing and terminates in Bangkok it was only natural that we would arrange a pre-tour of China and a post-tour of Thailand and a stop-over in Tokyo on the way home. A few days before departure we were told that the two other men who were to be part of our group cannot make it and so if we agree than we are the group. So off we went to the Far East for the longest (34 days) nature adventure tour of our lives effectively on a private tour. This has been by far the most intellectually and physically demanding trip of our lives. We endured and we enjoyed every minute of it to its fullest. Most importantly we learned a lot about the Far East probably more so than "regular" tourists because of the private nature of the trip. Imagine mom and I, a guide and a driver every day on this exotic tour. As a result we believe that we have gained a much more intimate and more personal and more candid understanding of the countries we toured and thus were part of a truly unique experience. Throughout the trip I kept a travel log literally in real-time recording our observations, feelings, impressions and adventures which we shared with our family back home. Join us on this wonderful tour with this book which we will cherish and we hope that you`ll enjoy.



Memories Fade But Impressions Last.

Following are the 10 `Big Picture` impressions we brought back from our tour:

1. Bhutan is a jewel in the rough. Experiencing Bhutan restores your belief in the human endeavour.












2. China (Beijing) is rich, modern and the infrastructure is awesome. Chinese tourists are rich, obnoxious, spoiled and ubiquitous.














3. Worship in Asia is an (almost) full time occupation. Religion is big business.














4. Buddhism is far more complex than we knew. The core tenants are very hard to conceptualize











5. Left alone by Humans nature is beautiful.







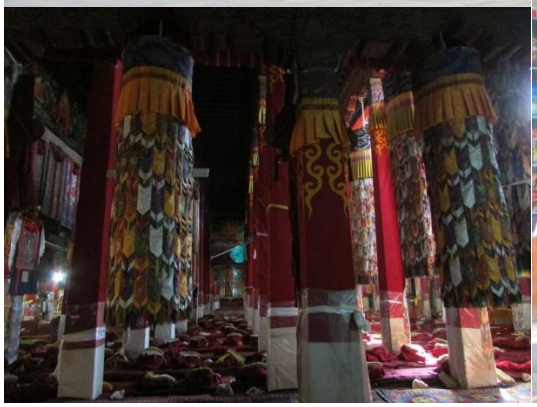



6. The Chinese are really squeezing the Tibetans: Chinese migration for jobs. No future for the young, Short life expectancy due to respiratory and heart disease for the aging.










7. Hinduism is better left for the Hindus if Katmandu is a sample.











8. Thailand is for the young and dirty, especially Bangkok.



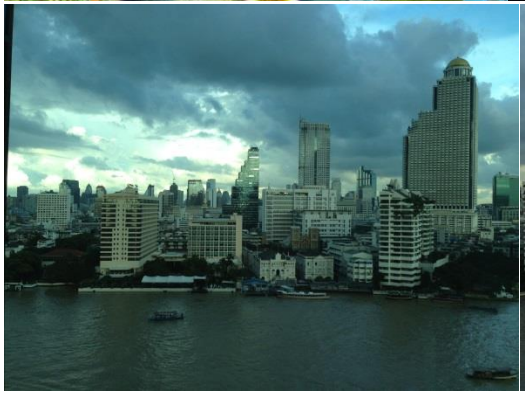


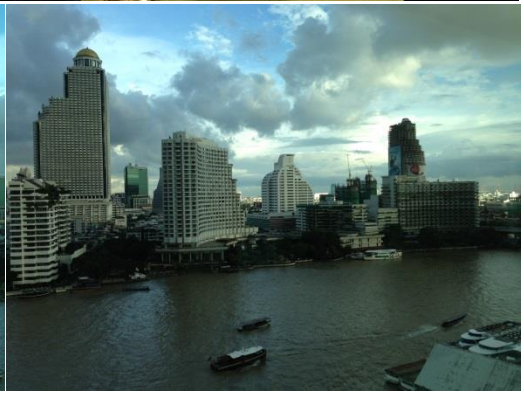












9. The influence of Western (pop) culture is very strong. Imitating USA is an expression of progress and status.

















10. The people of the East are genuinely friendly, helpful and are willing to assist dumb tourists as a second nature.









